BRIDGEPORT AVENUE ELEMENTARY SCHOOL
Hartford Public Schools
1540 Bridgeport Avenue, Hartford, CT 06106
(860) 555-0300 | sgiles@hartfordschools.org
STAFF HANDBOOK
2026-2027 School Year
Principal: Shanice R. Giles
Assistant Principal: Valerie Moss

WELCOME

This handbook contains the policies, procedures, and expectations that guide our work together at Bridgeport Avenue Elementary. Please read it in full and keep it accessible. Questions about anything in this document should go to Valerie Moss in the first instance.

Our work here is grounded in one belief: every child who walks through our doors deserves a champion. That belief is not a motto. It is the standard by which we measure every decision we make, from how we greet a child at the door to how we design a lesson to how we talk about a family who is struggling. Hold to it.

SECTION 1 -- SCHOOL INFORMATION

School Hours: Students arrive 7:30 AM. School day begins 7:45 AM. Dismissal 3:00 PM.

Staff Hours: 7:00 AM to 4:30 PM, Monday through Friday. Late arrivals or early departures must be pre-approved.

School Address: 1540 Bridgeport Avenue, Hartford, CT 06106

Main Office Phone: (860) 555-0300

Principal Direct Line: (860) 555-0301

Assistant Principal Direct Line: (860) 555-0302

Front Office / Rose Delaney: (860) 555-0300, extension 1

Building Access: All certificated and classified staff receive a key fob for building entry. Lost fobs must be reported to Rose Delaney within 24 hours. Do not prop exterior doors.

SECTION 2 -- PROFESSIONAL EXPECTATIONS

Attendance and Punctuality

Staff are expected to be in the building by 7:00 AM. Chronic tardiness is addressed through the district's performance management process.

If you will be absent, notify both Valerie Moss and the substitute office no later than 5:30 AM. Do not leave a voicemail and assume coverage is arranged; follow up if you do not receive confirmation.

Personal days must be requested in writing at least 48 hours in advance, except in emergencies.

Professional Conduct

Treat every student, family, and colleague with dignity. This is not optional and it is not situational.

Confidential information about students, including behavioral records, academic data, health information, and family circumstances, may only be shared with staff who have a legitimate educational need to know. Do not discuss students in hallways, the parking lot, or any space where you may be overheard.

Social media: Do not post content about students, families, or staff in any form. This includes indirect references

that could identify individuals. When in doubt, do not post.

Dress Code

Professional attire is expected Monday through Thursday. Casual Friday is permitted; activewear and athletic shorts are not appropriate for instructional days. Spirit gear is welcome on designated school spirit days.

Cell Phones

Personal cell phones should not be visible or in use during instructional time. Emergencies requiring phone access during instruction should be coordinated with Valerie Moss.

SECTION 3 -- STUDENT SUPPORT AND DISCIPLINE

Bridgeport Avenue Elementary uses a multi-tiered support framework. Staff are expected to implement Tier 1 supports universally and to refer students showing early warning signs to the intervention team.

Tier 1 -- Universal supports

Restorative practices, consistent routines, positive behavioral reinforcement, and responsive classroom structures are in place school-wide. All staff complete restorative practices training in September.

Tier 2 -- Targeted supports

Students who do not respond sufficiently to Tier 1 receive additional support through small groups, check-in / check-out, or counselor meetings. Referrals go to Valerie Moss.

Tier 3 -- Intensive supports

Students with intensive academic, behavioral, or social-emotional needs receive individualized support. These cases are coordinated by Valerie Moss with the school counselor, special education staff, and, where applicable, community partners.

Discipline Philosophy

Our goal is to keep students in learning environments and to address root causes of behavior. Exclusionary discipline (out-of-school suspension) is a last resort and requires principal approval. Office referrals should be accompanied by documentation of what Tier 1 strategies were attempted.

Mandatory Reporting

All staff are mandated reporters under Connecticut law. If you have reasonable cause to believe that a child has been abused or neglected, you must report immediately to the Department of Children and Families (DCF) at (800) 842-2288. You do not need certainty; you need reasonable cause. Notify Valerie Moss or Principal Giles after you have made the report, not before.

SECTION 4 -- INSTRUCTION AND CURRICULUM

Curriculum

ELA: Hartford Reads structured literacy program, supplemented with leveled guided reading and independent reading.

Math: enVision Mathematics, supplemented with Bridges materials for intervention groups.

Science: FOSS kits, Grades K to 5.

Social Studies: District-adopted scope and sequence.

Lesson Planning

Lesson plans are submitted weekly to Valerie Moss by 8:00 AM every Monday. Plans should reflect the current unit standards, include formative assessment strategies, and note differentiation for students with IEPs or language needs.

Data and Assessment

Formative assessment is embedded in daily instruction. Benchmark assessments (DIBELS for literacy, district math screener) are administered three times per year: September, January, and April. Results are reviewed in grade-level data meetings.

Grade-Level Planning

Grade-level teams meet every Wednesday from 2:00 PM to 3:00 PM in designated meeting rooms. This time is protected for collaborative planning, data analysis, and student problem-solving. Attendance is required.

SECTION 5 -- SPECIAL EDUCATION AND MULTILINGUAL LEARNERS

Students with IEPs

IEPs are legal documents. All staff who serve a student with an IEP must know and implement the student's accommodations and modifications. Contact the special education coordinator with questions. IEP meetings are scheduled by the special education coordinator in coordination with families; classroom teachers are expected to attend.

English Language Learners

Students who are English Language Learners receive services aligned to their English proficiency level.

Co-teaching and pullout support are provided by the EL specialist. EL designations and service plans are in the student management system.

SECTION 6 -- SAFETY AND EMERGENCY PROCEDURES

Evacuation

Fire drill procedures are posted in every classroom. In an evacuation, teachers take the class roster and lead students to the designated assembly area. Account for all students and report to Valerie Moss at the assembly point.

Lockdown

In the event of a lockdown, lock the classroom door, cover the window, move students away from windows and doors, and remain quiet. Do not open the door until you receive the all-clear signal from administration via the PA system. All-clear code: "Blue sky, all clear."

Medical Emergencies

Call the main office at extension 1 immediately. Do not move a student who is injured unless they are in immediate danger. Stay with the student until help arrives.

Student Sign-Out

Students may only be released to adults listed on their emergency contact form. ID is required for anyone not personally known to the office staff. Do not release a student to an unverified individual under any circumstances; notify Rose Delaney immediately if someone attempts to collect a student without authorization.

SECTION 7 -- FAMILY ENGAGEMENT

Families are partners. Treat them as such.

Parent communication should be proactive, culturally responsive, and accessible. Translation services are available through the main office.

Concerns raised by families should be acknowledged within 24 hours and addressed substantively within three

school days.

All family concerns involving academic performance, discipline, or special services that cannot be resolved at the classroom level should be escalated to Valerie Moss.

SECTION 8 -- PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

PD Days: District-designated professional development days are listed on the Hartford Public Schools calendar.

All staff are required to attend unless on an approved leave.

School-Based PD: Monthly staff meetings (last Friday of each month, 7:00 AM to 8:00 AM, with coffee provided by Rose Delaney). Coaching cycles with the literacy coach and instructional coach are ongoing.

Ed.D and Graduate Work: Principal Giles models the expectation that learning does not stop at licensure. Staff pursuing graduate coursework are encouraged to share insights from their studies with colleagues.

SECTION 9 -- STAFF RECOGNITION AND SUPPORT

Recognition: Staff achievements, milestones, and contributions are celebrated at monthly staff meetings and through a weekly staff shoutout in the building communication.

Employee Assistance Program: Hartford Public Schools provides an EAP through ComPsych at (800) 570-9315.

Services include up to 6 free counseling sessions, legal consultation, and financial coaching. This is a confidential resource.

Principal's Open Door: Principal Giles's door is open from 7:00 to 7:30 AM and 4:00 to 4:30 PM most days. For anything that cannot wait, speak to Valerie Moss who will ensure it reaches the right person.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

I have received and read the Bridgeport Avenue Elementary Staff Handbook for the 2026-2027 school year. I understand that the policies contained herein are in addition to, and do not replace, Hartford Public Schools district policies and Connecticut state law.

Each staff member signs and returns an acknowledgment confirming receipt of this handbook for the 2026-2027 school year and understanding that these policies are in addition to Hartford Public Schools district policies and Connecticut state law. The signed acknowledgment records the staff member's name, signature, position, and the date, and is collected by Rose Delaney and kept in the staff file. Return signed acknowledgment to Rose Delaney by October 2, 2026.